

# So you're thinking about languages

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI.

General document translation came out at **8.8 out of 10** — the highest score of anything we measured anywhere.

Court and legal interpreting came out at **4.3**.

**Same languages. Same training. A 4.5-point gap** — the widest split inside any career we looked at.

So this isn't a question of whether languages are a career. It's a question of *which* one.

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## The 60-second version

- Document translation is the most exposed work in the entire index. That's settled.
  - Interpreting is genuinely protected — and pays \$350–\$1,200 a day at the specialist end.
  - **One statistic explains everything:** 73% of companies use AI translation internally, only 19% for regulated work.
  - The survival condition isn't quality. It's **consequence**.
  - And fluency has stopped being the qualification. It's now the entry ticket.
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## The statistic that explains the whole thing

Industry research found:

**73% of enterprises use AI translation internally. Only 19% rely on it for external or regulated communication.**

**That's the map.**

Internal documents, first drafts, understanding a foreign email, bulk content — automated completely, and it's not coming back.

External communication, regulated content, anything where an error has legal or medical consequences — still human, and increasingly so.

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## And here's why the split is so absolute

Look at what the two things cost:

|                                      | PRICE                                                           |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Machine translation                  | \$10–\$20 per million characters — fractions of a cent per word |
| Human translation                    | \$0.08–\$0.50 per word                                          |
| Specialist legal/medical translation | \$0.15–\$0.50 per word                                          |
| Live interpreting                    | \$80–\$250 per hour                                             |
| Conference interpreting              | \$600–\$1,200 per day                                           |

That's a cost difference of a hundred to a thousand times. No amount of "but the human is better" survives that gap for routine content.

**So what's left isn't the work that's done best. It's the work where someone has to be answerable for the result.**

A mistranslated medication instruction. A contract clause. Court testimony. An immigration document. In those situations nobody is optimising for translation cost, because the downside is a misdiagnosis or a wrongful conviction.

**The transferable idea:** when something becomes nearly free to automate, ask what survives. What survives is the version where being wrong costs something.

## Why interpreting is different from translation

People talk about these together. They're structurally different jobs.

**Translation is text in, text out.** Asynchronous. Reviewable. Correctable. Nobody's in the room. Every one of those makes it automatable — and those are properties of the *medium*, not of how hard it is.

**Interpreting is a person, in a room, in real time.**

You have to physically be there — in many legal and medical settings that's actually required by law.

**There's no draft.** You say the sentence and its consequences start immediately. No review, no second pass.

**You're personally accountable.** A certified court interpreter is answerable for accuracy in a way no system can be, and that certification attaches to you.

**And you handle what the text doesn't contain** — hesitation, tone, the witness who's frightened, the patient who's downplaying symptoms.

## The scores

| TRACK                              | SCORE |
|------------------------------------|-------|
| Court & legal interpreting         | 4.3   |
| Medical & healthcare interpreting  | 4.6   |
| Conference interpreting            | 5.0   |
| Literary & creative translation    | 6.1   |
| Localization & transcreation       | 6.9   |
| Technical & specialist translation | 7.6   |
| General document translation       | 8.8   |

**And note where this started.** Document translation was already at 7.7 back in 2023 — before the current AI wave. This displacement didn't start with ChatGPT. It mostly finished during it.

Which makes translation the most mature example in our whole index — the closest thing we have to seeing where other professions end up.

## What we won't soften

**The generalist translation market has collapsed and it isn't coming back.** Rates at the floor have hit \$0.05 a word. A career built on "I'm good at languages" has no economic foundation left.

**Post-editing is now a big part of the market** — checking and fixing machine output. It's real work. **It pays materially less than translation did.** Better to know that now than discover it at 24.

**Most of this market is freelance**, with everything that means: variable income, no benefits, and finding clients being a second job.

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## Where the money actually is

The protected end is genuinely well paid:

- **Court interpreting: \$350–\$750 per day**
- **Conference interpreting: \$600–\$1,200 per day**
- **Live interpreting: \$80–\$250 per hour**
- **Specialist translators (legal, medical, technical): \$60–\$150 per hour**

**And here's the crucial trend: generalists face falling rates while specialists have held or increased theirs.**

BLS projects around **6,900 new interpreter and translator openings a year** through 2034, with the strongest prospects in Portuguese, Mandarin, Korean, Arabic and Spanish — and **"particularly strong for interpreters who combine language fluency with domain expertise in law, medicine or technology."**

That sentence is basically your career strategy.

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## So what should you actually do

- 1. Aim at interpreting, not translation.** **That single choice is worth 4.5 points on our scale.**
- 2. Get certified.** Court interpreting and medical interpreting certifications are what turn language ability into protected work.
- 3. Pair your language with a real subject** — law, medicine, engineering. **The differentiator now is the domain, not the language.** The rate data proves it.
- 4. Target regulated sectors.** Healthcare, courts, government, immigration. Compliance rules around language access are *expanding*, and every one creates demand for an accountable human.

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## Does this actually sound like you?

The most important trait now: **do you love languages and something else?** Language alone has stopped being a career. Language plus law, medicine or engineering is a good one.

It also suits people who:

- Can **hold concentration under pressure** — interpreting is cognitively brutal in bursts
- Are comfortable with **accuracy that matters**, where an error has consequences
- Are **self-directed**, since most of the market is freelance
- Are genuinely interested in **people**, not just in text

Harder if you want salaried stability early, or if you're drawn mainly to written translation as a craft — that's the exposed end.

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## What actually matters when picking a course

- **Is there real interpreting training?** Not translation with an interpreting module — actual practice. It's a distinct skill trained differently.
  - **Does it support court or medical certification?**
  - **Can you pair the language with a substantive second subject?** Many language courses still don't make this easy.
  - **Does the curriculum deal honestly with machine translation and post-editing?** A course that ignores it is preparing you for a market that's gone.
  - **Where do graduates work at two years** — interpreting, specialist translation, post-editing, or outside languages entirely?
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## Two things worth doing

**Watch a court or medical interpreter work**, if you can arrange it. It's a completely different job from what most people picture, and it'll tell you fast whether it appeals.

**Then find someone working in languages** and ask what share of their income comes from translation, interpreting and post-editing. The proportions will tell you more than any careers talk.

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## One last thing

Nothing here says loving languages is a mistake.

It says fluency has stopped being the qualification and become the entry ticket — and that being the person in the room, accountable, when two people absolutely have to understand each other, is work that isn't going anywhere.

Aim there deliberately. It's four and a half points better, and it pays considerably more.

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### If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- [Interpreters and Translators — Occupational Outlook Handbook](#) — government data on openings and pay.
  - [American Translators Association](#) — the professional body and the certification landscape. Worth understanding before you choose a course.
  - [Translation rates in 2026](#) — the actual rate data, including the gap between generalists and specialists. Read it for the economics.
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*There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the economics in detail, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.*